

PICKIN' COTTON

A while back I was driving in an area where cotton is still grown. The fields had recently been picked. You could see the scraggly bits of cotton that were still stuck to the drying plants out in the fields. Wisps of cotton fuzz were hanging onto the roadside weeds and barb wire fences where they had blown out of the ~~cotton~~ wagons that had hauled off their loads to the gin.

Seeing that cotton field I was reminded of my one experience at picking cotton. That was when I was a kid growing up in southern Oklahoma. This was back when cotton picking was still done by hand. About 1931 was the time. My family lived in a "company town" which was made up of the families whose men worked for the OG&E at the power generating plant. I went to a rural consolidated school.

Every year after school took up it would come cotton picking time and the whole school would shut down so that all the people could get their cotton picked. The farm kids had to help with the picking and there was no point in keeping a school open when about four out of five were farm kids. Anybody whose folks didn't plant cotton, would go pick for those who did. As best as I can recall this took place during two or three weeks in October. The pay, as I remember, was somewhere in the neighborhood of two cents a pound. Do you know how much cotton it takes to make a pound?

Two of my friends, Buddie Watkins, Sap Ray and I had decided we were going to make ourselves some of that money that was going to start changing hands in the southern Oklahoma cotton patches. We had been hearing about a big carnival show that was coming to Ada and we wanted to be able to go into town with enough money to make all the rides and maybe even waste some on the games.

We let it be known that we were expert pickers and were willing to be hired by whoever might need our help. (All this took was putting your name on a list at the school.) We figured we could handle it. After all, what was the big deal about reaching out and pulling a wad of cotton off of a bush and sticking it into a big cloth sack? We were selected and assigned to one of the many farms in the area.

The day we were to start picking, Sap, whose real name was Junior, had arranged for his mother to drive us over to the farm where we were to pick. We had been told to pack a lunch every day and to be at the farm ready to go into the field at five a.m. When we started down the highway it was dark. When we got to the farm it was still dark.

The three of us, along with several others, were told to get into an old high sided wagon. It was being driven by a blue overall clad man. He looked just about as faded as his overalls and he wore a straw hat that would have passed for a bundle of grass that had been picked up off the road. There were two worn out looking mules hitched to the wagon. After everyone was on board, the old man flipped the reins and the mules leaned into the harness. We were off to make our fortune.

We started down a rutted red dirt road. Sap and I had managed to sit up with the driver, mainly because Sap had told him he knew how to use the hand brake which was on the side of the frame. Before long we wished that we hadn't been so eager to sit up front with the driver.

Sitting on that front seat put us right behind the backside of those two mules, one of which would start to break wind right in our faces every time they broke into a trot. We went down quite a few hills on our way out to the cotton field so that meant that the ~~windy~~ ^{windy} mule would start doing his thing every time we started down hill. It didn't seem to bother the farmer much, but Sap and I found it a little harder to take since we were on the side behind that cussed mule. The ride out to the field took about half an hour. Believe you me we were plenty glad to get down on the ground. That old mule must have fed on onion weed the night before. Whoooooooooooo.

We were all lined up and handed a big white sack which hung around your neck and trailed out behind you. It looked to be about six feet long. I swear it was big enough to hold four or five grown men.

I thought to myself, "If I ever fill this thing up ^{just} one time I'll make a fortune."

The farmer told us to be sure to "pick clean". What he meant was, to get all the cotton off the boll and not to leave a lot behind. We were also told to not put any leaves or boll husks in the sack with the cotton. Whenever our sack got too heavy to drag, then we could come to the wagon, have it weighed and get the amount marked by our name and then go out and do it all over again.

Everyone started in a separate row. There were ten or twelve of us ^{blacks} ~~negroes~~ altogether, some school kids and some adults. Two of the adults were ~~negroes~~ who always helped out their white neighbors every year. It had begun to lighten some and as the sun became visible I could see we were in one heckuva big cotton field. Those rows looked a country mile long and they stretched out toward a grove of cottonwood trees at the far, far end. Getting to those trees was to become our most important goal that day. By mid-afternoon it was to become an obsession.

We were bent over working our particular row. There was a lot of talk at first among the younger pickers, mostly about the carnival that was coming to Ada and all that we were going to do when we got to go to it. The grown-ups said little, just kept their heads down and picked. I noticed that they were also getting out ahead of us. It didn't take more than about an hour of this good honest labor for me to realize that this way of earning money was no piece of cake.

By about nine o'clock in the morning we felt like we had been working all day. Our shirts were soaked through with sweat, it was even coming through the front of my denim overalls. The hat I had chosen to wear seemed to hold the sun's heat and concentrate it around my head like a portable oven. Gnats swarmed at our ears and up our noses. Big green flies crawled on our hands and arms as if seeking to bathe in our body juices. Shake 'em off and in a few seconds they were at us again. We were miserable. We were tired. We were hungry. We were angry at each other for ever thinking this was a good way to make some money.

The grown-up pickers were so far out the field ahead of us that trying to keep up with them no longer became a concern of ours.

Our main concern was survival.

All we thought about was making it to the line of trees at the far end of the field and plopping down to rest in their shade. Then we could perhaps gain enough strength to make it back to the other end where the hauling wagon stood. We emptied our sacks each time we got back to the wagon.

"Ain't no use totin' all that weight ifn' you don't have to" one of the ~~negro~~^{black} men had wisely advised us. We took his advice. We needed all the help we could get.

Another hour had passed and by then we were starving. It had been over five hours since we had eaten breakfast. There was only one clear answer to our problem. We had to have food. We took our sack lunches from under the wagon next to the drinking water can and when we reached the cottonwood grove, we dropped our sacks and began to eat our lunches. I'm sure, as we sat there under those trees eating our lunch meat sandwiches and biting into an apple or some cookies, we knew in the back of our minds it was folly to not leave a little something to snack on later. We resisted the urge, however, to do what was prudent or practical, or even necessary. We ate it all. The brown paper bags did manage to survive our gorging.

Most reluctantly we hung those miserable sacks over our necks and started back to our labor which, by now, ~~we~~ had come to consider sheer torture. The sun was now high in the sky. It cooked our bodies. Thirst was an ever present thing. Our lips were cracking and our faces burned from the sun and the sweat and the gnats and flies. I prayed to get snake bit so I could be taken away from this hellish place. When we got to the wagon we drank water from the big tin water can. It was now warm and no longer refreshing. It didn't taste any better than the sweat that rolled into the corners of our mouths. When the others weren't looking we poured water over our heads. This helped, but not for long.

At noon time a bell which hung on the wagon was rung. This was the signal for all work to stop and for everyone to eat lunch. We were closer to the grove of trees than we were to the wagon so we drug ourselves into that oasis in our desert and questioned the lack of intelligence we had shown in having already eaten all our food. We were hungry again but there was nothing in the cupboard. It was bare. We were too embarrassed to try to ~~smooch~~ anything off of those who were sharing our misery. We walked further back into the trees where it might be cooler. It was there that we found our salvation.

A small, quiet, sandy bottomed creek was noiselessly flowing past our unbelieving stares. Sap didn't say a word. He just jumped in, clothes and all. Then he hollered and laughed and made funny watery noises. Buddie and I followed him, but we did strip down to our undershorts. I could have drowned and been happy. We splashed and jumped and ducked each other, and did all kinds of foolishness that boys do when they get into a country creek. We became normal again. We didn't hate each other. We didn't resent the grownups being able to pick faster and better than we could. We probably wouldn't even have minded if that old windy assed mule had've walked up and said hello as only he could do it.

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At the height of our euphoria the bell rang and we faced the fact that we still had a way to go.

The rest of that day has always been fuzzy in my memory. Subconsciously, this bitter experience from my past was pushed into the hidden chambers of my mind which are reserved for such things as picking cotton and getting shot at in battle. Somehow, some way, we managed to finish out the day. Quittin' time was five o'clock I think, it may have been six. Whenever.

We emptied our last loads of cotton, got the tally from the man on the wagon and then he paid us for our days work right there on the spot. I don't remember how much we made. I think it was about two or three dollars ~~apiece~~ *piece*. I do remember we didn't go back the next day... ~~or~~ the next. There were fields and fields of cotton in Ponotoc County, Oklahoma but they would be picked by some body else. Not me. Not Sap. Not Buddie.

That weekend the carnival set up in town and we all went together, our meager earnings supplemented by some parental assistance. We rode all the rides. We went in the tent and saw the man with three legs and a woman without any head who they said was still alive. She'd move her arms and cross her legs ... stuff like that.

"Shoot, that ain't real." said Buddie, our scientific friend. "They do that with mirrors."

"She at least wouldn't have to smell that ole mule," Sap offered. We all laughed and went out of that tent of wonders into the temptations of the carnival midway.

We ate greasy hamburgers, and popcorn and hot dogs and drank soda pop like we might never have had any in our lives before. We played Bingo and Sap won a set of cheap glass dishes which he said his Mom would really like.

We all three tried to get a prize out of those glass cases where they have a miniature crane with a claw on the end of a chain. It's supposed to drop down and pick up something and dump it out through a slot. There were all kinds of gadgets in that case that any young country boy would have traded his pocket knife for. There were little cameras. There were toy cars and airplanes. There were leather billfolds, "genuine ivory" hair combs. There were tiny pistols that were supposed to fire real bullets. We put our dimes in the slot and the machines would start to whirl and clank, then that little crane would jerk around inside that glass case. It would suddenly drop, after having passed right over a real doozie of a prize and it would land smack on top of something that was so big the claws would'nt even begin to be able to grab it. We'd all shout and moan and cuss at our bad fortune. The operator of this "test of skill" finally called us over to him after we were getting ready to walk away in disgust.

"Boys, I tell you what I'm gonna do." He smelt like he must have been drinking bay rum hair tonic. "You boys have really tried hard and I hate to see such nice guys leave empty handed. Now don't tell anybody I did this.." He was looking up and down the midway like he expected the county sherrif to pounce on him at any time... We became his co-conspirators as we drew close about him waiting to hear what he was gonna do for us.

"Don't tell anybody I did this but you boys deserve a prize. Here's a brand new pocket comb for each one of yus." We were cheered by his largesse.

At least we weren't leaving empty handed.

"Gee, thanks mister," we sounded like a boys chorus. Those cheap combs probably cost us at least a dollars worth of dimes which we had dropped into the bottomless, insensitive pit of the claw machine. We didn't care.

We were all down to our last ten or fifteen cents when Sap put the cap on the whole evening.

"Hey, I know what let's do, let's go get some cotton candy." He was laughing so hard he almost couldn't say it.

Buddie kicked him in the shin. I was too sick to care.

PICKIN, COTTON

~~TR~~ A while back I was driving in an area where cotton is still grown. ~~THE~~ The fields had recently been picked. You could see the scraggly bits of cotton that were still stuck to the drying plants out in the fields, ~~and~~ wisps of cotton fuzz were hanging onto the roadside weeds and barb wire fences where they had blown out of the cotton wagons that had hauled their loads off to the gin.

~~Seeing that field I was~~
Whenever I see a cotton field I'm always reminded of my one experience at picking southern cotton. That was when I was a kid growing up in ~~rural~~ Oklahoma. This was back when cotton picking was still done all by hand, About 1931 was the time. My family lived in a "company town" which was made up of the families whose men worked for the OG&E at the power generating plant. I went to a rural consolidated school.

~~TR~~ Every year after school took up it would come cotton picking time and the whole school would shut down so that all the people could get their cotton picked. The farm kids had to help with the picking and there was no point in keeping a school open when about four out of five kids were farm kids. Any body whose folks didn't plant cotton, ~~then these kids~~ would go pick for those who did. As best as I can recall this took place during two or three weeks in October. The pay, as I remember, was somewhere in the neighborhood of two cents per pound. 

Do you know how much cotton it takes to make a pound?

~~Never mind about that though.~~

Two of my friends, Buddie Watkins, ~~and~~ Sap Ray and I had decided we were going to make ourselves some of that ~~big~~ money that was going to start changing hands in the southern Oklahoma cotton patches. We had been hearing about a big carnival show that was coming to Ada and we wanted to be able to go into town with enough money to make all the rides and maybe even waste some on the games.

We let it be known that we were expert pickers and were willing to be hired by whoever might need our help. (All this took was putting your name on a list at the school.)

We figured we could handle it. After all, what was the big deal about reaching out and pulling a wad of cotton off of a bush and sticking it into a big cloth sack? We were selected and assigned to one of the many farms in the area.

The day we were to start picking, Sap, whose real name was Junior, ~~(but nobody~~
~~ever called him by his real name, not even his mother.)~~ Sap had arranged for ^{his mother} ~~her~~
to drive us over to the farm where we were to pick. We had been told to pack a
lunch every day and to be at the farm ready to go into the field at five a.m.
When we started down the highway it was dark. When we got to the farm it was still
dark.

The three of us, along with several others were told to get into an old high
sided wood wagon. It was being driven by a blue overall ^{clad} ~~covered~~ man. He looked
just about as faded as his overalls and he wore a straw hat that would have passed
for a bundle of grass that had been picked up off the road. There were two worn
out looking mules hitched to the wagon. After everyone was on ^{board} ~~the wagon~~, the old
man flipped the reins and the mules ^{leaned} ~~strained~~ into the harness. We were off to
make our fortune.

We started down a rutted red dirt road. Sap and I had managed to ~~get to~~ sit
up with the driver, mainly because Sap had told him he knew how to use the hand
brake which was on the side of the frame. Before long we wished that we hadn't
been so eager to sit up front with the driver.

Sitting on that front seat put us right behind the backside of those two mules,
one of which would start to break wind right in our faces ever time they broke into
a trot. We went down quite a few hills on our way out to the cotton field so that
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We were all lined up and handed a big white sack which hung around your neck and trailed out behind you. It looked to be about six feet long. I swear it was big enough to hold four or five grown men. I thought to myself,

" If I ever fill this thing up one time I'll ~~be lucky.~~ *make a fortune.* "

The farmer told us to be sure to "pick clean". What he meant was to get all the cotton off the boll and not to leave a ~~lop~~ behind. We were also told to not put any leaves or boll husks in the sack with the cotton. Whenever our sack got too heavy to drag, then we could come to the wagon, have it weighed and get the amount marked by our name and then go out and do it all over again.

Everyone started in a separate row. ^{of us} There were ten or twelve ~~altogether~~, some school kids and some adults. Two of the adults were negroes who always helped out their white neighbors every year. It had ~~gradually~~ begun to lighten up some ~~some~~ and as the sun ^{became visible} ~~began to climb a little~~ I could see we were in one heckuva big cotton ~~field~~ ^{a country mile} ~~filed~~. Those rows looked ~~about a mile long~~ and they stretched out toward a grove of cottonwood trees at the far, far end. Getting to those trees was to become our most important goal that day. By mid-afternoon it was to become an obsession.

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By about nine o'clock in the morning we felt like we had been working all day. Our shirts were soaked through with sweat, it was even coming through the front of my denim overalls. The hat I had ^{chosen} ~~chose~~ to wear seemed to hold the sun's heat and concentrate it around my head like a portable oven. Gnats swarmed at our ears and up our noses. Big green flies crawled on our hands and arms as if seeking to bathe in our body juices. Shake 'em off and in a few seconds they were at us again. We were miserable. We were tired. We were hungry. We were angry at each other for ever thinking this was a good way to make some money.

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"Ain no use in totin' all that weight ifn' you don't have to" one of the negroe men had wisely advised us. We took his advice. We needed all the help we could get.

Another hour had passed and by then we were starving. It had been over five hours since we had eaten breakfast. There was only one clear answer to our problem. We had to have food. We took our sack lunches from under the wagon next to the drinking water can and ~~when~~ we reached the cottonwood grove we ^{dropped} ~~dumped~~ our ^{sacks} ~~lead~~ and began to eat our lunches. I'm sure as we sat there under those trees eating our lunch meat sandwiches and biting into an apple or some cookies we knew in the back of our minds it was folly to not leave a little something to snack on later.. We resisted the urge, however, to do what was prudent or practical, or even necessary. We ate it all. The brown paper bags did manage to survive our gorging.

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At noon time a bell which hung on the wagon was rung. This was the signal for all work to stop and for everyone to eat lunch. We were closer to the grove of trees than we were to the wagon so we drug ourselves ^{into} ~~onto~~ that oasis in our desert and questioned ~~ourselves on the~~ ^{lack of} intelligence ~~or lack thereof~~ we had shown in having ^{eat all our food.} already ~~dined~~. We were hungry ~~again~~ again ~~by this time~~ but there was nothing in the cupboard ~~anymore~~. It was bare. We were too embarrassed to try to mooch any thing off of ~~some of the~~ those who ~~were~~ were sharing our misery. ~~WE~~ walked further back into the trees ~~to get back~~ where it might be cooler. It was there that we found our salvation.

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At the height of our euphoria the bell rang and we faced the fact that we still had a way to go.

The rest of that day has always been fuzzy in my memory. Subconsciously, this bitter experience from my past was pushed into the ~~back~~ hidden chambers of my mind which are reserved for such things as picking cotton and getting shot at in battle. ~~This must be what happened.~~ Somehow, some way, we managed to finish out the day. Quittin'time was five o'clock I think, it may have ~~even~~ been six.

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